

LECTURE NO 1: *Professional Ethics*

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ORGANIZATION OF LECTURE 1

- Definition.
- Ethical Theories.
- Branches of Ethics.
- Laws and Ethics.
- Personal Ethics.
- Professional Ethics.
- Developing an Ethical Code.
- Advantages of Professional Ethics.

DEFINITION AND BASIC IDEA

- Greek word : Ethos / Ethikos = Character
- Concerned with the principles of right conduct.
- Study of value or quality.
- Deals with the concepts of right, wrong, good, bad, responsibility, moral duty and obligation.
- Principles of conduct governing an individual or group.
- "Ethic is a study of morality".

4 ETHICAL THEORIES.

1. UTILITARIANISM
2. DUTY ETHICS
3. RIGHT ETHICS
4. VIRTUE ETHICS

UTILITARIANISM

- **Utilitarianism** : It holds that those actions are good that serve to maximize human well-being. Emphasis in utilitarianism is not on maximizing the well-being of the individual but rather on maximizing the well-being of society as a whole and as such it is somewhat a collectivist approach. e.g. Dam construction
- Two Parts:
- **Act utilitarianism**: focuses on individual **actions** rather than rules.
- **Rule utilitarianism**: differs from act utilitarianism, **moral rules** are most important.

DUTY ETHICS

- It comes with terms that there are duties that should be performed regardless of whether these act badly to the most good.
- Duty Ethic and Right ethics are similar to each other.
- Immanuel Kant says **moral duties** are fundamental ethical actions which can be written down as **duties**. *Be honest, don't cause suffering for others, be fair to others.*

RIGHT ETHICS

- They emphasize that we all have moral rights, and any action that violate these rights is ethically unacceptable.
- Right ethics was formulated by John Locke statement: humans have the right to life, liberty and property.

VIRTUE ETHICS

- Virtue is defined as moral distinction and goodness. A virtuous person exhibits good and beneficial qualities.
- Actions are considered right if they support good character traits and wrong if they support bad character traits.
- Focuses on words such as responsibility, honesty, competence, loyalty, trustworthiness, fairness, caring, respect, citizenship.

BRANCHES OF ETHICS

- 01. Normative Ethics
- 02. Meta Ethics
- 03. Applied Ethics
- 04. Moral Ethics
- 05. Descriptive Ethics

01. NORMATIVE ETHICS : (LARGEST BRANCH)

- Classifies actions as right and wrong.
- How individuals can figure out the correct moral actions that they should take
- Norm = standard – It is the attempt to find a single test or criterion for what constitutes moral behaviour and what does not.
- Bridges the gap between meta-ethics & applied ethics – how to judge right from wrong.

02. META ETHICS

- Seeks to understand the nature of ethical properties and judgments
- Where the ethical notions came from and what they mean?
- Investigates whether our ethical principles are merely social inventions ?
- Focuses on universal issues, the will of God, the role of reason in ethical judgments

03. APPLIED ETHICS :

- Applies normative ethical theories to specific controversial issues.
- Applying theories from philosophers to ethics in everyday life.
- Medical ethics, engineering ethics, legal ethics, political ethics, environmental ethics.

04. MORAL ETHICS :

- Questions how individuals develop their morality, why certain aspects of morality differ between cultures and why certain aspects of morality are generally universal.
- Moral ethics rarely change within a culture / religion.
- Not related to professional work.
- Influenced by society culture and religion.

05. DESCRIPTIVE ETHICS :

- More specific in its approach.
- Focuses on how human beings actually operate in the real world rather than theorizing on how they should operate.
- Study of people's views about moral belief.
- Analyses peoples moral values, standards and behavior.
- Based on data and facts.
- Ask what actually is.

LAW AND ETHICS

- Law → A set of rules and regulations, created by the government to govern the whole society.
- Ethics cannot be legislated, it has to come through conviction and self-discipline.
- Ethics and laws are independent of each other.
- What is legal (law) may not be ethical (ethics) and vice-a-versa, Gambling, drinking alcohol.
- Both laws and ethics are necessary for a stable and functioning society.

PERSONAL ETHICS

- Personal ethics involve one's morals and values.
- They are instilled during childhood by parents, family and friends.
- Deep-rooted principles – how one follows it determines the kind of person he is.

PROFESSIONAL ETHICS : (BUSINESS ETHICS)

- Refers to the ethics that a person must follow in respect to their interactions and business dealings in their professional life.
- Attempts to apply general(common) moral principles to business activities in order to resolve or to clarify the moral issues developed in business.

DEVELOPING AN ETHICAL CODE

- An individual's ethical code has its roots in his childhood.
- Come from variety of resources – family, religion, community, school, friends.
- Over the course of time, his experience and changing circumstances drive him to return and reshape his ethical code multiple times.
- Business ethics = personal ethics code + workplace experience.
- Business ethics also change.
- A company's business code is different from person's ethical code.
- Business ethics can be quantified more easily.

ADVANTAGES OF PROFESSIONAL ETHICS :

(1) **Attracting and retaining good employees.**

- Talented individuals at all levels want to be compensated fairly for their work and dedication.
- Career advancement within the organization – based on the quality of work not on favoritism.
- People wish to join the organization with high ethical values.
- Trustworthy, reliable environment, team work, productivity and employees growth support.

ADVANTAGES OF PROFESSIONAL ETHICS :

(2) Investor Loyalty :

- Investor loyalty and trust come from a company promoting an ethical culture which provides a foundation for efficiency, productivity, and profits.
- When shareholders/investors see a company that does not behave with integrity, they are less likely to invest into the company.
- Investors are much aware of ethical environment, efficiency, productivity and profits.

ADVANTAGES OF PROFESSIONAL ETHICS :

(3) **Customer satisfaction :**

- It is a marketing term that measures how products or services supplied by a company meet a customer's satisfaction is important.
- Company should evoke trust and respect among customers for enduring success through good ethical practices.

ADVANTAGES OF PROFESSIONAL ETHICS :

(4) **Avoid legal problems :**

- If a company's management in pursuit of profit, may not fully comply with the environmental regulations or labour law, safety hazards or using substandard raw material, the penalties can be severe, legal fees and fines are severe. This resulting negative publicity can damage company's reputation.
- Highest ethical standards take time to train every member of the organization about the conduct.

ADVANTAGES OF PROFESSIONAL ETHICS :

5) **Better for society :**

- Beneficial for the company – through its behavior, impact and environmental foot prints.

THANK YOU

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